



P13 · 40 CARDS, AGES 2 TO 5

The Toddler Big Feelings Cards

Forty printable cards for toddler emotions. Ten naming cards (so they have a word for it), ten body cards (so they can find it in their body), ten calm-down cards (one small action each), and ten reset cards (for the after). No "happy face / sad face" reductionism. Made by a parent who has been on the kitchen floor.

Soothemade **Notes**

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you print

My oldest had a meltdown in a Target parking lot at age three that lasted forty-seven minutes. I timed it. He could not tell me what was wrong because he genuinely did not know. He just had a body that felt like static.

These cards are the thing I wish I'd had in my bag. Not a discipline tool. A vocabulary.

The point of these cards is not to ask a melting-down child to identify their feeling. That is asking a fish to describe water. The point is, after the storm, when there is enough breath in the room for words, to lay a few cards on the floor and say "was it any of these?" And then to do that again next month. And the month after.

Over time, you'll notice they reach for the same one or two cards. That is the door. That's the conversation that wasn't possible before.

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These cards are not a substitute for child mental health care. If your child has prolonged or severe difficulty regulating, sleep disturbances tied to mood, or any thoughts about self-harm, please see a pediatric provider. Children's mental health is a real medical field and worth the appointment.

How to print and use these cards

Print

- US Letter or A4, three cards per page, on cardstock if you can
- Cut along the printed lines
- Two sizes available in the file: standard (3.5" × 5.5") and large (5" × 7") for younger kids who need bigger pictures
- Punch a hole in one corner and put the deck on a small ring, if you want

Where to keep them

- A basket by the calm-down corner
- A drawer in the kitchen
- The diaper bag if you are out a lot
- Not on display where they become a thing the child must do

How to introduce them

Pick a calm moment, not a meltdown moment. Spread out five or six cards. Say something like: "These are some big-feeling cards. We have one called 'jealous.' Want to look?"

That's it. No quiz, no goals. Let them pick the cards up. Let them put them down. Let them ignore the deck for a week.

When to use them

After a meltdown, not during. After someone is back in their body. After the cup of water and the lap-time and the kneeling-down-eye-level.

You point at three or four cards and say "was it one of these?" The child points. Or doesn't. Either is information.

When not to use them

- During the meltdown. Words are not landing then. The card deck is not a magic wand.
- As a behavior chart. "If you can name your feeling you get a sticker" is not what these are for.
- As a discipline trigger. "If you don't use the cards, you're in trouble" turns them into a punishment and the child stops engaging.

The cards are a language tool, not a compliance tool.

Card pack one, naming cards (10)

Each card has the feeling word at top, a small line-drawing in the middle, and one sentence at the bottom in plain kid language.

Furious

Furious is when your body feels too big for the room. Your hands want to throw and your voice wants to be loud. Furious is real. Furious passes.

Jealous

Jealous is when someone has the thing you want, and you wish they didn't have it. It feels hot in your chest. Most people feel jealous. Even grown-ups.

Embarrassed

Embarrassed is when you wish everyone had been looking the other way. Your face feels hot. You want to disappear into your shirt. It will end. It always ends.

Lonely

Lonely is when there are people around but you still feel like nobody knows you are there. Lonely is a feeling, not a fact. You can be lonely with people. You can be alone and not lonely.

Disappointed

Disappointed is when something you really wanted to happen did not happen. It feels heavy. It is okay to cry about it. The thing you wanted was a real thing.

Overwhelmed

Overwhelmed is when too many things are happening at once and your brain can't sort them. Lights, sounds, talking, expectations. Your body might want to hide. That is fine.

Scared

Scared is when something feels bigger than you. The dark. A dog. A big noise. A bad dream that is over but is still in your room. Scared is your body trying to keep you safe.

Jumpy

Jumpy is when you feel scared even when nothing is happening. Your body is waiting for something bad. Sometimes the only fix is a hug and time and a soft thing.

Ashamed

Ashamed is when you did something and now you wish you hadn't. It feels like a stomach-flip. Ashamed is not the same as bad. You are still good. The thing you did is what we will look at together.

Missing-someone

Missing-someone is when a person you love is not here. It is a heavy feeling. It is also a love feeling. Missing-someone means you have someone to miss, and that is a good thing too.

Card pack two, body cards (10)

Each card has a body-sensation in plain language. The drawing shows a small outline of a child's body with the sensation area shaded. No quiz, no quiz, no quiz.

My chest is fast

My heart is going faster than my breath. My breath wants to come quick and shallow. Some people call this fluttery. Some call it racing. Both are right.

My hands won't stop

My hands want to do something and I don't know what. Squeeze a soft thing. Push a wall. Squeeze and let go. Squeeze a different soft thing.

My ears hurt and they don't really hurt

Sound is too loud. Or there is too much sound. My ears want quiet, or they want to be covered. This is okay. Quiet is allowed.

My belly is full of static

My stomach feels buzzy. Like a TV with no channel. I might not be hungry. I might be hungry. It is hard to tell.

My eyes want to close

The room is too bright, or too much is happening, or I am tired in a way that I cannot say. My eyes want a dark place. A blanket-tent counts.

My legs want to run

My legs feel jumpy from the inside. They want to move and I don't know where to. Running in a circle is allowed. Stomping is allowed. Jumping ten times is allowed.

My throat feels stuck

Words want to come out but they can't. Like a sock got stuck. Sometimes a sip of water helps. Sometimes pointing is enough.

My skin feels itchy where it isn't

I want my shirt off. Or my socks. Or the tag. Or the seam. My skin doesn't feel right and I can't say why. Soft clothes help. Naked time helps.

My face wants to hide

My face is hot and I want to put it on a soft thing. Pillow. Stuffed animal. Your shoulder. Sometimes I want to be alone with my face. Sometimes I want you here.

I'm tired even though I just woke up

My body is in bed but my brain is already running. Or my brain is asleep but my body is buzzing. I might need a quiet morning. I might need a long hug. I might need both.

Card pack three, calm-down cards (10)

One small action per card. The kind of thing a body can do when the brain is not online.

Drink in three slow sips

Take a cup of water. Take three slow sips, counting. One. Two. Three. Put the cup down. See how you feel.

Push the wall

Put both hands on a wall. Push as hard as you can for ten seconds. Stop. Notice your hands. Push again if you want.

Squeeze and let go

Make your hands into very tight fists. Hold for five seconds. Open them all the way. Wiggle your fingers. Do it three times.

Hum into a pillow

Pick up a soft pillow. Hold it close to your face. Hum a long low sound into it. Hum again. Notice your chest.

Stomp ten times

Stand up. Stomp your feet ten times. Count them out loud or in your head. Try not to think about anything else. Just the stomps.

Cold water on your face

A splash of cold water on your face or wrists can reset your body fast. Your body thinks you went swimming, and it calms down.

Find five things

Look around. Find five things that are blue. Or five things made of wood. Or five things smaller than your hand. Your brain will follow.

Wrap up

Get a blanket. Wrap yourself up. The tightness can help your body feel held. Like a hug from yourself.

Tell me three things

Tell a grown-up three things, in any order. They don't have to be about feelings. They can be about anything. The words on the way out help.

Big breath, slow out

Take a breath in for four counts. Hold it for two counts. Let it out for six counts. Do it three times. You can do it lying down.

Card pack four, reset cards (10)

For the after. When the body is back in the room.

What just happened

We had a big feeling. We did our best. Now we are back. Let's notice that we are back.

What will help next time

If this happens again, what would help? A quiet room? A walk? A hug? Tell me one thing. I will remember.

Who is still on the team

Even after a big feeling, we are still on the same team. You and me. Always.

I forgive you

Sometimes during a big feeling we say things we don't mean. I forgive you. The thing you said was the feeling talking. Not the you-of-you.

I forgive myself

Sometimes I lose my temper too. I am working on it. I forgive myself, and I am sorry, and I am still your grown-up.

Soft hands

We are soft-hands people. Even when we are angry, we can keep our hands soft. We can punch a pillow. We can squeeze a soft thing. We can keep our hands soft.

Words and feelings are different

A word is a thing you say. A feeling is a thing you have. You can have a feeling without saying a word about it. And you can say a feeling without yelling it.

My job is not to make you happy all the time

My job is to keep you safe and to love you. My job is also not-to-give-you-everything-you-want. Both of those jobs are because I love you.

Your job is not to keep me happy

Sometimes I will be sad. Or tired. Or worried. It is not your job to fix that. It is my job to take care of myself. I am taking care of myself.

Tomorrow

Tomorrow we will start again. Tomorrow is not a punishment. Tomorrow is just the next day. We will both be okay tomorrow.

A short note for the grown-up

Some things that are true about toddlers and emotions, in case you needed to hear them in plain language:

- A toddler's prefrontal cortex (the part of the brain that does self-regulation) is not built yet. It is being built right now, slowly, by experiences like the one you just had. You losing your temper does not undo the build. You repairing afterward is part of the build.
- A meltdown is not "manipulation." Toddlers do not have the cognitive scaffolding to manipulate adults. A meltdown is a system overflow.
- You will lose your temper sometimes. Repair is more important than perfection. The phrase is: "I was angry. I am sorry. Let's try again." That, said once a week for a decade, builds a person.
- A child who is using their feelings vocabulary at age four learned it somewhere. They learned it from someone who used it with them. That someone is you.

If this is helpful, more cards may come. There are no extra cards yet. The forty here are the ones I needed when my kids were small.

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A page for the kid who is reading this on their own

When a kid is around six or seven, they sometimes pick up the cards on their own. If that is you, hi.

These cards are for you to use when you want, or not. Nobody is going to grade you on the cards. They are not homework. If you find a card that feels like a feeling you have, that's enough. If you don't, that is also okay. Some feelings don't have cards yet. Some feelings don't have words yet.

You are doing a good job of being a person. It is hard to be a person. The grown-ups are also doing a hard job of being people. We are all on the team together.

Numbers to keep (for the parent)

PEDIATRIC PROVIDER

Name: _____ Number: _____

PEDIATRIC THERAPIST (if any)

Name: _____ Number: _____

SCHOOL COUNSELOR (if any)

Name: _____ Number: _____

US PARENT STRESS LINE (FREE, CONFIDENTIAL)

1-800-422-4453 (Childhelp, 24/7)

US SUICIDE & CRISIS LIFELINE

988 (call or text, 24/7)

POISON CONTROL (US)

1-800-222-1222 (24/7)



From [Soothemade Notes](#), a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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